

Nirvan Sutra

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Chapter 7: The Turiya State

Aadisatv

First Section - Waking, Dream and Deep Sleep

In the previous chapter, we listened to the Mahavakyas. They pointed the seeker directly toward the real Self: Tat Tvam Asi - You are That. Aham Brahmasmi - I am Brahman. Ayam Atma Brahma - This Atma is Brahman. Prajnanam Brahma - Consciousness is Brahman. These statements guided the seeker beyond the limited identity of body and mind. What is being recognized as the witness is the direction of Atma, and Atma is not separate from Brahman. Consciousness is not one more passing experience; it is the ground of all experience.

Now we look at something very ordinary, yet deeply mysterious - the states of experience. Every day the seeker passes through three states: waking, dream, and deep sleep. We wake, work, dream at night, fall into deep sleep, and then wake again. This happens every day, yet we rarely look at it through the eye of inquiry.

Advaita asks: who knows these three states? Waking came and went. Dream came and went. Deep sleep also came and went. Is there a ground that makes the recognition of all three possible? This question opens the direction of Turiya.

Right now you are reading. The body is sitting or lying down. The eyes see the words. The mind understands meaning. Sounds may be present. Sensations may be present in the body. A thought may arise: “I understand this,” or “This is subtle.” All of this is happening in the waking state.

In waking, the world appears solid. Home, family, work, people, roads, body, time, and space all seem real and unquestionable. The experiencer is very active here. It says, “I am working,” “I succeeded,” “I failed,” “I was respected,” “I was hurt,” “This happened to me.” Because body, world, people, and results are all present, identification becomes very strong.

Earlier chapters examined this. The body changes. The mind changes. The world appears through Maya. Ego takes all of this and forms a “me.” Neti-neti says: all of this is known; therefore it cannot be the final Self. Now look at waking in the same way. Waking also appears in experience. It begins in the morning, continues through the day, and recedes at night. What comes and goes cannot be the final ground.

The waking world feels stable, but look closely. Waking experience is constantly changing. The morning mind is different from the afternoon mind. The same person feels dear at one time and difficult at another. The same body feels light at one time and heavy at another. The same task feels inspiring one day and burdensome the next. Even within waking, experience is never fixed.

This does not mean waking life has no value. In practical life, the waking world matters. The body must be cared for, work must be done, relationships must be honored, compassion and responsibility must be lived. But inquiry asks: is waking the final truth, or is it also a known state?

Now look at the dream state. In a dream, a complete world may appear. There are people, places, events, emotions, time, fear, joy, loss, meeting, running, searching. While the dream is happening, it feels real. If someone chases you in the dream, fear is real in that moment. If you meet someone dear, joy is real. The dream experiencer says, “I am running,” “I am afraid,” “This is happening to me.”

Then waking happens. Suddenly the dream-world changes its status. The dream body, dream people, dream places, and dream events belonged only to that state. Now ask gently: in what was the dream known? How can we later say, “I had a dream”? The waking body was lying in bed, yet a whole dream-body and dream-world appeared. This shows that a state can feel very real while it is happening, and yet its reality can be re-understood when the state changes.

Do not rush to say that waking is exactly the same as dream. The point is subtler: within a state, experience feels real; when the state changes, our understanding of that experience changes. Waking is known. Dream is known. What knows both?

Now we come to deep sleep, or sushupti. In deep sleep, the waking world is absent. The dream world is absent. There is no clear body-experience, no active thought, no role, no story, no success, no failure. The ordinary experiencer is quiet.

Yet on waking we say, “I slept well,” or “I did not know anything.” This is a profound statement. If absolutely nothing was known in any way, how is the absence later reported? Deep sleep is mysterious because the mind is not functioning in its usual way, yet existence has not ended. If you had completely disappeared, how could waking occur?

Be careful: deep sleep is not liberation. In deep sleep, there is rest, but not clear Self-knowledge. Avidya remains because there is no conscious recognition of Atma. Still, deep sleep indicates that the ground of existence is not destroyed when body-mind activity becomes quiet.

Put the three states together. Waking comes. Dream comes. Deep sleep comes. Then waking returns, and you say, “I woke,” “I dreamed,” “I slept.” The content of the states differs, but some continuity allows their recognition. This continuity points toward a deeper ground.

Summary: waking is known, dream is known, and even the absence-like condition of deep sleep is later known. The three states change. What is the ground of all three? This question leads us toward Turiya.

Practice for today: before sleep, say gently, “The waking state is being known.” If a dream is remembered in the morning, notice, “The dream state was also known.” On waking, pause and notice, “Deep sleep, where nothing was known, is now remembered.” Then ask: waking came, dream came, sleep came - what knows their coming and going?

Second Section - Turiya: Not a Fourth Passing State, but the Ground of the Three

In the previous section, we looked at waking, dream, and deep sleep. Waking appears, dream appears, deep sleep appears, and each passes. Yet there is a continuity through which we say, “I woke,” “I dreamed,” “I slept.” Now the question becomes: what is the ground of these three states?

In this course, Turiya means the unmoving awareness that knows waking, dream, and deep sleep, yet is not limited by any one of them. Waking changes. Dream changes. Deep sleep comes and goes. Their coming and going can be recognized only because there is a deeper ground. Turiya points to that ground.

Turiya is not a state the mind must reach in the future. It is not a special meditation experience. It is not a vision, a light, an extraordinary peace, or a wave of bliss. Anything that comes and goes is a state. Turiya is that in whose presence states come and go.

Calling it the “fourth” can create confusion. Language sometimes calls it fourth because we first speak of three states - waking, dream, and deep sleep - and then point beyond them. But Turiya is not a fourth passing state. It is the ground of all three. It is silently present in all three and not limited by any of them.

Many seekers imagine Turiya as a special experience: one day the mind will stop, the body will disappear, light will spread, and that will be Turiya. Deep peace and subtle experiences may occur in meditation. They can be respected, but they are not Turiya. Peace came and was known. Bliss came and was known. Emptiness came and was known. A deep state came and was known. Then it passed, and that too was known. What is known is experience. What comes and goes is a state. Turiya is the ground because of which even that special experience was known.

Look at waking now. Words are being seen. Meaning is being understood. Bodily sensations are present. Thoughts may arise. Sounds may be heard. All this is waking. Ask: in what is this known? Words are known, body is known, thought is known, sound is known, understanding and confusion are known. The knowing is already present in waking.

Turiya is not far from waking. Waking is known in it. But attention is usually absorbed in waking objects - body, work, relationships, results, world. The ground is not absent; attention is busy with names and forms. Like a screen forgotten while one is lost in the movie, Turiya is not hidden, but attention is carried away by the story.

In dream too, experience appears. There are dream events, dream emotions, a dream body, a dream experiencer. Later we say, "I had a dream." The dream was known. The content differs from waking, but experience was still illumined. Turiya is not a character inside the dream. It is the ground in which the dream appeared.

Deep sleep is subtler. In deep sleep there is no waking world, no dream, no active thought, and no ordinary experiencer. Yet existence does not break. On waking we say, "I slept," "I knew nothing." Turiya is not an experience inside deep sleep. It is the ground that remains when the presence and absence of experience are both later recognized.

The witness and Turiya are not two separate truths. The witness is first recognized in waking life: "A thought is arising; I know it." As inquiry deepens, the seeker sees that waking itself is known, dream was known, and deep sleep too belongs to the sequence of known states. The witness opens into the understanding of Turiya - awareness not confined to any state.

This also connects to the Mahavakya Prajnanam Brahma - Consciousness is Brahman. In waking, consciousness illumines the world. In dream, consciousness illumines the dream. In deep sleep, the absence of mental content is later known. Consciousness is not limited to one state. Turiya is that limitless, unmoving consciousness.

So do not ask, "How do I obtain Turiya?" What is obtained is absent before and present after. Turiya is not absent. This very experience is known in it. Thoughts arise in it. Witnessing points toward it. It is to be recognized, not acquired.

Turiya is present in ordinary moments too. While drinking tea, taste is known. While speaking, words are known. While anger arises, anger is known. While

sorrow arises, sorrow is known. If you look only for Turiya in peaceful states, you will think it is lost when agitation comes. But agitation too is known in it.

Summary: Turiya is not a fourth passing state. It is the ground of waking, dream, and deep sleep. It is not to be attained as an experience. It is to be recognized as the basis in which all experiences and states appear.

Practice for today: notice three moments - an active working moment, a moment of imagination or memory, and a quiet or empty moment. In each, ask: in what is this experience known? Is the knowing presence changing with the experience? Am I trying to hold a special state? Remember gently: Turiya is not a state to be acquired; it is the ground in which states come and go.

Third Section - The Unknowable: That Which Cannot Be Known as an Object

After hearing about Turiya, the mind naturally asks: “If Turiya is real, how do I know it?” This question is sincere, but it hides a subtle problem. The mind wants to know Turiya as an object - something to see, feel, possess, remember, and later say, “Yes, I have known it.”

Here, great care is needed. Turiya is not a known object. The witness is not an object. Atma is not an experience. Consciousness is not something the mind can place in front of itself. Why? Because it is the very basis of knowing.

In this section, we call this direction “unknowable” - not absent, not dark, but not knowable as an object. In Hindi, this can be understood as agyeya or the sense of agyeyata/agyaata: that which cannot be grasped by ordinary knowing.

How do we usually know things? The eye sees form. The ear hears sound. The skin knows touch. The mind understands thoughts. The intellect grasps meaning. Memory holds impressions. Then we say, “I know this.” A cup is seen. A sound is heard. A thought is understood. An emotion is felt. These are knowable objects; they appear in experience.

But the witness, Atma, consciousness, or Turiya is not an object like this. The eye cannot see it, because the seeing of the eye is known in it. The mind cannot grasp it as a thought, because thoughts arise in it. Emotion cannot reveal it as an emotion, because emotion is known in it. Experience cannot contain it, because experience comes and goes in it. It is unknowable as an object, yet it is not absent. It is too near to be placed at a distance.

Take the example of the eye. The eye sees colors, shapes, distance, and light. But the eye does not directly see its own seeing. It may see a reflection in a mirror, but seeing itself is not an object standing in front of the eye. Seeing is the eye's function.

Similarly, consciousness knows everything - body, mind, thought, sorrow, peace, waking, dream. But consciousness itself does not appear as an object. Whatever appears is known. Consciousness is that in which appearing is known.

Or take the example of a lamp. At night, a lamp lights the room. It reveals the table, wall, book, and person. Now ask: with what will you light the light? Light does not need another light to be revealed as light. It is self-luminous in its own way. In the same way, consciousness reveals thoughts, emotions, body, and world. It does not need another consciousness to reveal it.

The mind has a limit here. The mind can listen to teaching, think, question, reason, and help with neti-neti. But final recognition is not an object in the mind. The mind is known. How can the known grasp the knower as an object?

This does not mean truth is forever unknowable in the sense of being absent. It means truth is not objectifiable. It is not seen as a form, heard as a sound, felt as an emotion, or held as a thought. It is self-evident as the very fact of being and knowing.

When you say, "I am," do you need external proof? Before thoughts, there is the simple sense of being. When identity with body and mind becomes loose, this basic being opens toward the recognition of Atma. It is not known as an object. It is rested in as your own nature.

The experiencer has one final trick. It says, "I want the experience of Atma," "I want the experience of Turiya," "I want the experience of Brahman." But this desire is also known. The one asking for an experience is the experiencer. Whatever the experiencer gets will be another experience, and every experience comes and goes. Therefore it cannot be the final truth.

There is also a sacredness in "I do not know." The mind usually fears not knowing. It wants answers. But in inquiry, there comes a moment where the mind humbly sees, "I cannot grasp this as an object." This is not defeat. It is the right recognition of the mind's boundary. When the mind bows, a quieter door opens.

The Mahavakyas must be heard with this understanding. They do not hand the mind an object called Brahman. They point away from body-mind, away from the experiencer, away from all known things, toward the basis of knowing itself.

Summary: the witness, Atma, consciousness, and Turiya cannot be known as objects, because they are the basis of knowing. Unknowable does not mean absent. It means not objectifiable. Truth is nearer than any object, because every object is known in it.

Practice for today: when a thought arises, notice it is known. When an emotion arises, notice it is known. When a body sensation arises, notice it is known. Even the desire to know is known. Then ask gently: can the one that knows all this be known as an object? Do not answer quickly. Rest for a few moments in the knowing that is already present.

Fourth Section - Recognizing Turiya in Life and Completion of the Chapter

Now the question is: how is this understanding lived? Is Turiya only to be remembered in deep meditation? Does Turiya mean withdrawing from life? Does it mean that mind, emotions, and the world must disappear? No. Correct understanding of Turiya does not end life. It clarifies the ground of life.

Waking life will continue. Dreams will come. Sleep will come. Relationships, work, emotions, body, and mind will continue. But the seeker slowly recognizes that behind all of this there is an unmoving presence of knowing, not confined to any one state.

Start with waking life. The day is happening. The body is acting. The mind is thinking. The world is seen. People are speaking. Work, food, relationships, and responsibilities are present. Usually the seeker becomes body, mind, role, and experiencer. Then something happens and the thought arises, "This happened to me."

In the direction of Turiya, the seeker gently sees: this is the waking state; body is experienced; mind is active; the world appears; all this is known. This does not require leaving the world. It only asks that waking too be recognized as a known state.

Ordinary moments are the true doorway. While drinking tea, taste is known. While walking, body movement is known. When someone calls your name, reaction is known. When a message arrives, mental movement is known. Praise is known. Criticism is known. None of these moments are small. Every moment is an opening back toward the ground.

Emotions will arise - fear, sorrow, anger, love, compassion, loneliness. Turiya does not ask you to suppress them. Fear is known. Sorrow is known. Anger is known. Love is known. Emotion comes, changes, and passes; the knowing presence does not change with it. This does not make the seeker emotionless. It makes the seeker honest, steady, and less bound.

In relationships too, Turiya is useful. When someone close speaks harshly, hurt arises. The experiencer says, "I have been insulted." Ego says, "I must respond." The body tightens. Old memories rise. If the seeker can pause even slightly, he can see: words are being heard, the body is reacting, the mind is making a story, hurt is arising, and all this is known. The reaction may not vanish immediately, but a space appears. In that space, witness-consciousness is remembered.

Work is another field. Effort is happening. Plans are made. Results will come. Success may say, "I am successful." Failure may say, "I am a failure." In the direction of Turiya, the seeker sees: work is being experienced, effort is being made, excitement or stress is known, expectation is arising, all within waking. Work is not abandoned. It becomes clearer, less bound to identity.

Practice too must be seen this way. Sometimes meditation is peaceful. Sometimes it is restless. Sometimes there is depth; sometimes nothing special happens. The experiencer says, "Today practice was good," or "Today nothing happened." In Turiya's direction, peace is known, restlessness is known, depth is known, the thought "nothing happened" is also known. Practice is not about collecting experiences; it is about returning to the ground of experience.

Deep sleep should also be understood correctly. The quietness of deep sleep is not Turiya. In deep sleep, mental activity is absent, but clear Self-knowledge is not present. There is rest, but not awakened recognition. Turiya is not unconsciousness or mere absence of experience. It is the ground of waking, dream, and deep sleep.

Keep the unknowable nature of Turiya in mind. It is not an object, not a possession, not a spiritual badge. If the mind says, "I have attained Turiya," see that too. If ego says, "My state is higher," see that too. These are known layers. Turiya does not claim itself. It is the silent ground.

The fruit of recognizing Turiya is lightness. What felt heavy begins to loosen. Emotions arise, but do not drown the seeker as before. Success comes, but ego does not inflate as much. Failure comes, but identity does not collapse fully. A second fruit is stability. Outer life continues, but an inner ground is gradually recognized. A third fruit is compassion. Hard separation softens. A fourth fruit is simplicity. The seeker no longer needs to prove a state.

Now the journey of this chapter can be gathered. First, we examined waking, dream, and deep sleep. Then we saw that Turiya is not a fourth passing state but the ground of all three. Then we understood the unknowable nature of Turiya: it cannot be grasped as an object because it is the basis of knowing. Finally, we saw how Turiya can be recognized in ordinary life, emotions, relationships, work, and practice.

The essence is this: states change, experiences come and go, the mind is sometimes active and sometimes quiet, but the ground of knowing is unmoving. Turiya points to that.

The next and final chapter will be Moksha Ki Jhalak - A Glimpse of Liberation. We will see that liberation is not a faraway fantasy and not merely something after death. It is clarity at the root of bondage, the loosening of false identity, stability in the witness, and living with compassion and responsibility even while understanding Maya.

Practice for this week: three times a day, recognize the state. When busy in work or the world, pause and say, "The waking state is being known." When the mind moves into memory, fantasy, or worry, say, "The mind is making a small dream-world; this too is known." When quietness or emptiness appears, say, "Quietness too is known." Then ask: is that which knows also a state? Do not answer. Rest.